

Appendix A



State of Practice of {domain} Software

Survey Consent Script

The purpose of this study is to conduct a current state of the practice analysis of software in select research software domains for the purpose of understanding quality and assisting in the future development of such software.

Study procedures

This survey will take about 30 minutes. The questions are about research software development, including obstacles you encountered while developing the software, and about the development process. Your answers will be temporarily recorded and securely saved on Microsoft Teams. The data will be retained for 3 years after the study and then deleted.

Risks

The risks have been described in the letter of consent that you received. To review, there are no physical risks, there is little psychological risk. You may feel that your work is being scrutinized. We assure that our questions are objective and technical, and do not suggest a course of action. The social risk associated with this interview is minimal. We will keep your identity private. However, maintaining the privacy of interviewed sole developers, or members from a small developer team, may not be possible since their identities can potentially be inferred. The interviewee will have to accept this risk if they choose to be interviewed. All personal information will be stored securely on password protected email accounts on password protected computers. You do not need to answer questions that make you feel uncomfortable or that you do not want to answer, and you can withdraw at any time. After the interview all that would be required to withdraw your answers would be an e-mail to me or the principle investigator (Dr. Smith). You can withdraw up until we analyze all data of this research project on August 8th, 2026.

Information that could identify you will not be published or shared beyond the research team unless we have your permission.

Benefits

The answers to these survey questions will help us analyze the current state of practice of software development, and provide insight into common or best practices for the benefit of future software development. However, participants may not benefit from participating in the study.

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Voluntary participation:

- Your participation in this study is voluntary.
- You can decide to stop at any time, even part-way through the survey for whatever reason, or up until August 8th, 2026. Please let us know by email (smiths@mcmaster.ca) if you would like to stop.
- If you decide to stop participating, there will be no consequences to you.
- If you decide to stop we will ask you how you would like us to handle the data collected up to that point.
- This could include returning it to you, destroying it or using the data collected up to that point.
- If you do not want to answer some of the questions you do not have to, but you can still be in the study.
- If you have any questions about this study or would like more information you can call or email Dr. Smith, at **1-905-525-9140 X27929** or smiths@mcmaster.ca

This study has been reviewed by the McMaster Research Ethics Board and received ethics clearance under project 8215. If you have concerns or questions about your rights as a participant or about the way the study is conducted, please contact McMaster Research Ethics Office by phone: (905) 525-9140 ext. 23142 or e-mail: mreb@mcmaster.ca.

We would be pleased to send you the study results when they are complete. Please let us know if you would like a summary (last survey questions).

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Consent questions, before survey questions:

- Do you agree to participate in this study knowing that you can withdraw at any point with no consequences to you?
- Yes, I agree and wish to continue
- No, I do not agree

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Survey Question

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[Option to receive a copy of the study results, after survey questions]

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- Optional: If you would like a copy of the study results, please provide your email address.
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